Homelessness in the US Fell the Most in More Than a Decade

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-11-08 5 min read

After years of climbing to record-high levels, the homeless population in the United States dropped more than 6% in 2025. That amounts to roughly 49,000 fewer people without housing. It is the second year in a row that homelessness has declined, following a smaller drop in 2024.

Housing and Urban Development Secretary Scott Turner announced the results of an annual count of people in communities around the country. "President Trump's actions to secure the border, get criminal illegals off our streets, and restore safety to our communities drove a historic decrease in homelessness," Turner said in a press release. The agency had not yet posted a detailed report.

A second independent analysis based on the same count, commissioned by the advocacy group National Alliance to End Homelessness, found a similar decline but credited different reasons. "It's good news that more people are getting housed, and that the programs that are funded by Congress are working," said CEO Ann Oliva.

Both analyses find there are still nearly 700,000 people in the US living in shelters or on the streets, significantly more than before the COVID-19 pandemic. The Trump administration cited its changes in immigration policy as a key factor in the decline. During the previous administration, New York, Chicago, Boston, and Denver all saw a surge in **asylum seekers** who turned up at homeless shelters. "That's also the four cities that have driven half of the drop most recently," said Devon Kurtz of the Cicero Institute, an administration ally on homelessness policy.

Kurtz also pointed to declines in cities like San Francisco, which is moving to support more **sober-living** options, housing that bans drugs and alcohol. But critics say that can send more people back to the street if they **relapse**, which is common. The administration argues that requiring people to be drug-free would help more people achieve recovery, and it wants to overhaul several billion dollars in homelessness spending and shift it toward short-term housing with mandated addiction and mental health treatment. So far, that plan has been blocked by courts.

The administration says the longstanding federal policy of getting people into permanent housing first, then offering voluntary treatment, has failed and is to blame for the pandemic spike in homelessness. But Oliva said programs that get people off the street without preconditions were a big part of the latest declines, especially among veterans. Homelessness among US veterans was down more than 7% last year, and has declined nearly 60% since 2010. By contrast, Oliva said more permanent housing is needed for people who have been homeless for a long time, and who are more likely to struggle with mental health problems and addiction. Unlike other groups, they saw a small **uptick** last year.

HUD also credited a crackdown on homeless **encampments** after the Supreme Court ruled

in 2024 that cities can ban people from sleeping and camping in public places. Oliva said the analysis her group commissioned showed that cities with such bans "actually did worse than the national average." She noted the decline was broad and likely due to a number of factors, including softening rental markets in some places. Even though rents are still high, they are down from record peaks during the pandemic, which could slow the flow of newly unhoused people. There were also declines in places hit by major weather disasters, like western North Carolina and Hawaii, where relief efforts reached unhoused people as well.

Word Treasure

asylum seekers -- People who ask another country for safety because they fear harm at home.

sober-living -- Housing where people must stay free of drugs and alcohol.

relapse -- Going back to an old habit, such as using drugs or alcohol, after stopping.

encampments -- Groups of tents or shelters where people without homes live outdoors.

uptick -- A small rise in a number.

Background you need

Homelessness means living without a home of your own, in a shelter, a car, or on the street.

Each year, communities across the country count how many people are in that situation, so the government can see whether the number is rising or falling.

Housing programs try to help in different ways: some give people a home first and offer help with health or addiction afterwards, while others ask people to take part in treatment before or alongside housing.

The count is a snapshot, and different groups can look at the same numbers and disagree about what caused them to change.

Break it down

LEAD: US homelessness dropped more than 6% in 2025, about 49,000 fewer people, the second yearly decline in a row.

KEY EVENT: Housing and Urban Development Secretary Scott Turner announced the annual count and credited the Trump administration's border and safety policies.

+- CLAIM: Turner said the president's actions to secure the border and restore safety drove a historic decrease.

+- CAVEAT: The agency had not yet posted a detailed report.

KEY EVENT: A second analysis of the same count, commissioned by the National Alliance to End Homelessness, found a similar decline but credited different reasons.

+- WHO: CEO Ann Oliva said Congress-funded programs are working and more people are getting housed.

+- SCALE: Both analyses find nearly 700,000 people are still living in shelters or on the streets.

KEY EVENT: The two sides disagree about what caused the drop.

+- ADMINISTRATION: It cites immigration policy changes, and Devon Kurtz of the Cicero Institute says New York, Chicago, Boston, and Denver drove half of the drop.

+- HOUSING FIRST: Oliva says programs that house people without preconditions drove much of the decline, especially among veterans, whose homelessness is down more than 7% in the past year and nearly 60% since 2010.

+- OTHER FACTORS: Oliva also points to softening rental markets and relief efforts in places hit by weather disasters, like western North Carolina and Hawaii.

KEY EVENT: The administration wants to overhaul homelessness spending toward short-term housing with mandated addiction and mental health treatment.

+- CRITICISM: Critics say requiring people to be drug-free can send them back to the street if they relapse.

+- COURT: So far, the plan has been blocked by courts.

+- CAMPS: HUD also credited a crackdown on encampments after the Supreme Court ruled in 2024 that cities can ban sleeping and camping in public places, but Oliva said cities with such bans did worse than the national average.

OPEN QUESTION: Which approach will bring the number down further: housing people first, or requiring treatment first?

Why it matters

Nearly 700,000 people are still without a home, so a drop in the numbers matters -- but the

disagreement over why it happened will shape how billions of dollars are spent on housing and help in the years ahead.

Test what you remember

1. How much did US homelessness drop in 2025?

- (A) More than 6%
- (B) More than 2%
- (C) More than 60%
- (D) More than 7%

2. About how many fewer people were without housing?

- (A) Roughly 100,000
- (B) Roughly 49,000
- (C) Roughly 14,000
- (D) Roughly 700,000

3. How many people are still living in shelters or on the streets?

- (A) Nearly 700,000
- (B) Nearly 49,000
- (C) Nearly 60,000
- (D) Nearly 100,000

4. By how much has homelessness among US veterans fallen since 2010?

- (A) More than 7%
- (B) Nearly 60%
- (C) More than 6%
- (D) Nearly 50%

5. Which four cities drove half of the recent drop, according to Devon Kurtz?

- (A) Boston, Denver, Miami, and Atlanta
- (B) New York, Chicago, Boston, and Denver
- (C) San Francisco, Los Angeles, Seattle, and Portland
- (D) New York, Chicago, Boston, and San Francisco

6. What did Ann Oliva's analysis find about cities with camping bans?

- (A) They did worse than the national average
- (B) They matched the national average
- (C) They were not included in the count
- (D) They did better than the national average

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: A 4: B 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. The Trump administration: Credits immigration policy and border security for the decline, says the housing-first policy has failed, and wants to shift spending toward short-term housing with mandated addiction and mental health treatment.

2. Ann Oliva, National Alliance to End Homelessness: Credits Congress-funded housing programs that house people without preconditions, says cities with such bans did worse than the national average, and says more permanent housing is needed for people homeless for a long time.

3. Devon Kurtz, Cicero Institute: Points to the four cities that drove half of the drop and to declines in cities like San Francisco that are moving toward sober-living options.

4. Critics of drug-free housing rules: Say requiring people to be drug-free can send more people back to the street if they relapse, which is common.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):